

Personal Development Journal

MAIE5535 – Entrepreneurial Journey Reflection

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At the beginning of this course, I treated entrepreneurship as something I could analyze but not really do. I was comfortable discussing other people's ventures, business models, and strategies, but much less comfortable proposing imperfect ideas of my own. I preferred structure, clear expectations, and solutions that already seemed feasible. In that sense, I approached entrepreneurship as an observer rather than a participant.

Over the past few months, that mindset has changed. Through case studies, company visits, pitching activities, and project discussions, I began to see entrepreneurship less as a personality type and more as a way of thinking and acting. I did not become suddenly fearless, but I became more willing to stay with uncertainty, test incomplete ideas, and think more seriously about how innovation connects to real human needs. Looking back, three main takeaways stand out most clearly.

1. Entrepreneurship Begins with a Real Problem, Not a Grand Vision

One of the most important lessons I learned is that entrepreneurship does not have to begin with a huge or revolutionary idea. The Stripe case was especially influential for me. What stayed with me was not just the company's success, but its discipline in solving a specific and frustrating problem well. Stripe did not begin by trying to transform the entire financial system. It began by making online payment integration easier for developers.

This challenged one of my old assumptions. I used to think that a "good" entrepreneurial idea had to sound ambitious from the start. Because of that, I often judged my own ideas too early: if they did not sound big enough, I assumed they were not worth pursuing. During this course, I gradually realized that this mindset was actually preventing me from thinking clearly. A focused problem can be a much stronger starting point than a vague big vision.

I noticed this change in my own behavior. In earlier discussions, I tended to jump quickly to features because features felt tangible. After reflecting on Stripe, I became more willing to stay longer with the problem itself: who exactly is struggling? What is inconvenient

in their current experience? Why are existing solutions unsatisfying? This shift also shaped a personal idea I began exploring outside class: an AI-assisted birdwatching travel platform. Rather than imagining a broad eco-tourism product, I found myself starting with a narrower question: what specific frustrations do birdwatchers face when trying to plan trips, find suitable companions, and make use of observation records? For me, the significance of this idea is not that it is already strong or ready to launch, but that I now know how to begin thinking about ideas in a more grounded way.

2. Uncertainty Does Not Always Require Speed; Sometimes It Requires Direction

A second major takeaway came from the NVIDIA case study. Before this course, I often associated entrepreneurial courage with speed, bold pivots, and visible confidence. NVIDIA showed me a different version of boldness: long-term commitment under uncertainty. Its development path suggested that fearlessness is not always about moving faster than everyone else; it can also mean staying committed to a direction before external validation becomes obvious.

This was personally important because uncertainty has always been uncomfortable for me. I like having enough information before acting, and I often interpret ambiguity as a sign that I should wait longer. The NVIDIA case made me rethink that habit. I began to understand that entrepreneurship does not eliminate uncertainty; it works through it. What matters is not having complete certainty, but having a reasoned direction and the patience to develop it.

I saw this change especially in the way I respond to ideas that are still immature. My earlier instinct was often to dismiss them quickly if they seemed too niche, too difficult, or too uncertain. Now I am more likely to ask a different question: what would be the next small step to test whether this direction is worth pursuing? That is a meaningful attitude shift for me. I am still cautious by temperament, but I no longer treat caution as a reason to avoid action altogether.

3. Innovation Only Matters if It Can Live in the Real World

The visit to Zhongke Minsheng Naiding Robotics left a deep impression on me because it showed that innovation is not only about technical sophistication. Hearing about the development of AI-powered nursing robots made me realize how much real innovation depends on context: workflows, regulations, user trust, safety, institutional adoption, and long periods of testing. A technically impressive idea is not enough if it cannot fit into actual human systems.

This changed the way I think about entrepreneurship more broadly. Before, I was more easily attracted by the novelty of technology itself. After the visit, I became more sensitive

to the conditions that make a solution meaningful and usable. In other words, I began paying more attention to implementation, responsibility, and fit.

This perspective also affected the way I think about my own ideas. Instead of asking only whether an idea is interesting, I now ask whether people would realistically use it, what barriers might prevent adoption, and what kinds of trust or incentives would be required. That shift from excitement about concepts to attention to context is one of the most valuable changes I experienced in this course.

4. How I Changed in Skills, Knowledge, and Attitudes

In terms of **skills**, I believe I improved in three areas. First, I became better at **problem framing**. Instead of beginning with solutions, I learned to define the user problem more precisely. Second, I improved at **communicating incomplete ideas**. Earlier in the semester, I often stayed quiet until I felt my thoughts were fully formed. Over time, especially in group discussions, I became more willing to share partial ideas and let them develop through conversation. Third, I developed more basic **validation thinking**. The pitching activities helped me understand that ideas need some logic of testing, feasibility, and prioritization, even at an early stage.

In terms of **knowledge**, I now understand entrepreneurship in a more complete way. Before, I mainly saw it as creativity and idea generation. Now I see that entrepreneurship also involves validation, adoption, monetization, regulation, and strategic focus. The different events in the course showed me different parts of this picture: Stripe highlighted problem-solution fit, NVIDIA showed long-term strategic positioning, Naiding Robotics emphasized real-world integration, and the pitching session revealed the importance of communicating feasibility and execution.

In terms of **attitudes**, the biggest change is that I no longer see entrepreneurship as something reserved for naturally bold people. I now see many entrepreneurial behaviors as learnable: noticing pain points, asking sharper questions, testing assumptions, and communicating imperfect ideas. I have also become more willing to work with uncertainty instead of waiting for it to disappear.

5. Challenges I Encountered and How I Tried to Overcome Them

One challenge I encountered was my tendency to dismiss my own ideas too early if they seemed too niche or difficult to scale. The birdwatching platform idea is a good example. My first instinct was to think: this is too specific, maybe too small, and probably too complicated to make meaningful. That reaction reflected an old habit of evaluating ideas too quickly based on scale or polish rather than on whether the user problem was real.

What helped me overcome this was a gradual shift in criteria. Through the course, I began

to understand that niche does not mean trivial. If a user group has a genuine frustration, then the idea deserves at least some exploration. I did not completely overcome this challenge, but I did start responding differently. Instead of rejecting an idea immediately, I began asking what evidence I would need, what assumptions I was making, and what a small first test might look like.

Another challenge was in group settings. I often hesitated to contribute early because I did not want to offer something underdeveloped. To work on this, I made a conscious effort to speak earlier in discussions and treat my ideas as drafts rather than final answers. This sounds small, but it changed the way I participated. I became less focused on being correct and more focused on being useful to the process.

6. How I Will Apply These Learnings in the Future

In the future, I want to apply these lessons in a practical way. First, I want to continue starting from real user problems rather than from impressive-sounding solutions. Second, I want to become more disciplined about testing ideas through small experiments instead of only thinking about them abstractly. Third, I want to keep balancing innovation with realism by asking not only whether something is novel, but whether it can be adopted responsibly and sustainably.

Whether I eventually build something of my own or work in an innovative team, I believe these habits will remain valuable. I may still prefer structure over chaos, but I no longer see that as incompatible with entrepreneurship. What has changed is that I am now more willing to begin with a small question, explore it seriously, and learn in public. For me, that is the most meaningful outcome of this entrepreneurial journey.